Ethnobotany of the Tambov Region According to Historical Sources: Aims, First Results, and Perspectives

Kovalenko, Kira
kira.kovalenko@gmail.com
European University at St. Petersburg, Russian Federation

Makhracheva, Tatiana
mahrachova@mail.ru
Tambov State University named after G.R. Derzhavin

The project “Ethnobotany of the Tambov region according to historical sources” is an ethnolinguistic and ethnobotanical study of the Tambov region traditional culture on the material of the lexical-semantic field “Plants”. Since the 19 th c., the region has attracted multiple dialectologists, ethnographers, folklorists, and botanists. Still, quite a lot of their field notes and observations have not been published or are scattered among numerous small-circulation publications (some of them are listed in Piskunva et al. 2002: 5–6). As a result, the complex study which systematizes and summarizes linguistic, folklore, and ethnographic materials regarding plants and their use in the region, does not exist.

The project aims to collect maximum historical information about plant names and their uses in the Tambov region. For this purpose, we extract linguistic, folklore, and ethnographic data about the plant world from archival documents and published sources (dictionaries, folklore collections, ethnographic literature, central magazines, regional press). In addition, we illustrate the historical data with interview texts, photos, video and audio materials collected during the fieldwork practice by the Tambov State University professors and students in the 20 th and 21 st cc. Such a method allows tracing the diachronic changes in the tradition. A bibliography on the Tambov region ethnobotany will also be available. Finally, we scan the herbarium sheets of the 19 th c., collected in the region.

The research is being conducted with the help of the *PhytoLex* database (*https://phytolex.eu-sp.org/*). It is a software and web-site specially developed for ethnolinguistic studies, which was already filled in during two previous research projects: " Russian Phytonyms in the Diachronic Aspect (11-17 cc.)" (Russian Foundation for Basic Research , 2017-2019) and "Plants and people in the Russian Empire of the 18 th century: knowledge and practice distribution among social classes” (European University at St. Petersburg, 2022-2024). By now, the database contains about 50,000 records of plant names supplied with citations from the texts in Russian, written from 11 th up to 18 th cc. It also includes pictures from the published books of the 18 th c. and scanned herbarium sheets of the same period. The scientific Latin plant names are given according to the *Plants of the World* (https://powo.science.kew.org/) and the Global Biodiversity Information Facility (https://gbif.org) portals.

The *PhytoLex* database allows filtering the material according to various search queries: vernacular and Latin names, time of records, sources, authors, text genres, functions (using plants in folk medicine, magic, veterinary, in calendar rites and life cycle rites, in regional cuisine, and so on), places of growing, trading and use, etc. Besides, a number of visualisations, which represent plant names synonymy and polysemy, word-formation and etymological connections, are available on the web-site.

For the purpose of the ongoing project, some modifications of the database structure are being made: new fields for geo coordinates and for audio and video files uploading as well as the means for their representation on the web-site are being created.

Representing the materials in the *PhytoLex* database will provide all the necessary information about plants important for the local culture. The query result is going to be structured as follows:

- vernacular plant names and names of its parts during various vegetation stages,
- attitude to a plant, its role in the traditional world-view,
- use in folk crafts,
- use in regional cuisine,
- use in folk medicine,
- use in meteorology,
- use in folk calendar rites,
- use in family cycle rites,
- image in legends, dreams, narratives etc.

For example, in the case of oak (*Quercus* sp.) the following information supplied with citations,

photo/audio/video fragments and exact locations of records is available:

- names for group of plants: *dubnyak* (*дубняк*) , *dubrava* (*дубрава*) , *dubovnik* (*дубовник*); names for acorn: zhaludki (*жалудки*) , *zheludochki* (*желудочки*); new shoots appearing: *dub razvivaetsya* (*дуб развивается*) , *dub razbukaet* (*дуб разбукает*) *;*
- attitude: beneficial,
- utilitarian function: used for house building and decoration, for homemade tools and barrels making,
- in medicine: used for treatment of hernia, diarrhea, illnesses connected with weight loss, for hair removal and against evil eye,
- in folk calendar rites: used as a decoration for Pentecost,
- in family cycle rites: used in birth and funeral rites,
- in legends: an explanation for toponyms and microtoponyms origin,
- serves as a metonym for myconony name: *poddubovnichki* (*поддубовнички*).

Thus, the *PhytoLex* database allows 1) presenting a unique pool of materials (dialect texts, multimedia materials) based on the user's search query; 2) promoting the expansion of multidisciplinary research; 3) define plant habitats and visualize them on the map.

We hope to replicate the software for a series of similar projects dedicated to the dialects and ethnobotanical traditions of other regions of Russia. It will open wide opportunities for comparative research in the field of dialectology, folkloristics, and ethnography.

Acknowledgement: The research is supported by the Russian Science Foundation (project No 25-28-01399).

Bibliography

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